RAINBOW BRIGADE



TCID 392-50

Game, Level, and Character Design

Final Project

Samantha Korson

WHAT IS RAINBOW BRIGADE?

Rainbow Brigade is a semi-open world CRPG in the vein of Baldur's Gate 3 or Divinity: Original Sin. It focuses on a group of six adult friends who gain extraordinary abilities which they use to protect their community and each other. Players will experience victory and defeat alongside the core team of characters, culminating in a story of trials, triumph, and overcoming impossible odds.

It is heavily inspired by the tokusatsu genre of shows, especially *Power Rangers* (and its Japanese counterpart *Super Sentai*) and *Kamen Rider*.



Inspiration for *Rainbow Brigade*.
Top right: *Himitsu Sentai Gorenger*. Top Left: *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers*.
Bottom: *Kamen Rider Revice*.

On the far-off world of Synthax One, a spaceship is launched containing six organisms that bridge the gap between biology and technology. These biocomputers have the unique ability to create a permanent bond with a sentient lifeform, granting them incredible superpowers.

On the somewhat closer world of Earth, six friends are walking through the park after a late dinner together. They have been friends for years and are now adults with their own jobs, relationships, and responsibilities. Their lives are changed forever when a meteor crashes in the forest nearby and they decide to investigate.

Suddenly armed with the fantastic ability to create armor and weapons out of "hard light," these six friends are thrust into the middle of a conflict that has been raging on Synthax One for years. The villainous Vince O'Ruin is determined to make Earth his own using his army of monsters. Only six millennials with powers they don't understand stand in the way of his total dominion.

GAME INTERFACE

Combat Interface

The combat interface takes inspiration from JRPGs like Persona 5 (interface pictured below). Like Persona 5, the menu should take advantage of all face buttons rather than the more traditional method using the arrow keys to select an option, with a single “confirm” button.

The colors of the interface will be bright and appear to be plastic, in the style of the toyetic weapons used in tokusatsu shows. In the event of a submenu, as in the “Create Construct” action, submenu content will replace the main menu.

The interface will also contain the party members’ health, stamina, and any status effects they are under. This section will be out of the way but still visible, likely in the top right corner. The currently acting character’s information will be larger to draw attention and make it easier for players to locate.



MEET THE PROTAGONISTS

On the pages that follow, you will meet the Rainbow Brigade: Rin, Morgan, Colin, Carter, Liz, and Zephir.

Each character has their own special combat abilities, but they also have several in common. These are:

Henshin

- Transforms characters from their human form to their superhero form
- Removed following transformation

Create Construct

- Special Abilities menu
- Replaces Henshin

Attack

- Basic attack with primary weapon

Defend

- Reduces damage taken until next turn

Finisher

- Heavy attack with primary weapon
- Usable when opponent has low health

Combo Finisher

- Heavier attack
- Usable when opponent has low health and ally is in range

RAINBOW RED

IDENTITY

Civilian Name

Rin

Pronouns

They/Them

Age

41

Orientation

Asexual/Aromantic

APPEARANCE

Height

5' 6"

Weight

130 lbs.

Human Form

Open flannel, band tee, jeans, high-top canvas sneakers

Superhero Form

Light armor with a musical theme. Primary weapon: guitar-shaped axe.

BACKSTORY

Rin is a millennial and grew up during the early days of the Internet. They have a small group of friends who they are intensely dedicated to, but do not get to see as much as they would like. They are considered the “realistic” one in the friend group. Their down-to-earth nature and way of seeing all sides of an issue have made them the de facto judge when conflicts arise.

They struggle to find their place in the world, never finding their calling despite years of searching. They are a hobby musician but have never felt a pull toward music as a profession.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Heartfelt Plea

Chance to convince enemy to disengage; chance of success increases inverse to enemy health

Inspire Ally

Grant a bonus to an ally's next action

RAINBOW ORANGE

IDENTITY

Civilian Name

Morgan

Pronouns

She/Her

Age

Late 30s

Orientation

Bisexual

APPEARANCE

Height

5' 6"

Weight

200 lbs

Human Form

Army jacket, band tee, torn jeans, leather boots

Superhero Form

Padded armor/heavy boots with a fire and metal theme. Primary weapon: oversized gauntlets

BACKSTORY

Morgan is a metal sculpture artist in her late-30s. Her art often focuses on the struggles of marginalized people, though it is often misunderstood. She is an activist and protester who feels strongly about keeping the most vulnerable members of her community safe.

She previously dated Liz, and though they are no longer together, they remain good friends. Morgan devotes all the energy she would put into a relationship into her art and her activism.

Morgan often comes across as abrasive, but her friends know that she is merely direct. That directness, when mixed with her passion, can often be misinterpreted as aggression.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Exploit Vulnerability

Increases damage done on next turn

Change Stance

Offensive Stance: Increases base damage done

Defensive Stance: decreases base damage taken

RAINBOW YELLOW

IDENTITY

Civilian Name

Colin

Pronouns

He/Him

Age

Mid-30s

Orientation

Gay

APPEARANCE

Height

6'1"

Weight

220 lbs.

Human Form

Black or blue business suit, fun tie

Superhero Form

Heavy armor with a book theme.
Primary weapon: tower shield

BACKSTORY

Colin works in a generic office setting. His friends often speculate on what his job is, but it is too boring for them to investigate. He is the only person in his friend group with a "traditional" job. He took it to support Carter through college and stayed to provide financial security for his family. He dreams of being an author "someday."

Colin is married to Carter. The two are the epitome of "opposites attract" from the outside. Colin appears to be reserved, but his friends know that he loves fiercely and always seeks to protect those he cares about. He has a very dry sense of humor and will roast you with a straight face.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Cover Ally

Redirects next attack against an ally to Rainbow Yellow instead

Taunt

Enemies focus on Rainbow Yellow and take a penalty to any attack made against other characters

RAINBOW GREEN

IDENTITY

Civilian Name

Carter

Pronouns

He/Him

Age

Mid-30s

Orientation

Gay

APPEARANCE

Height

5'3"

Weight

110 lbs.

Human Form

Graphic tee, jeans, sneakers

Superhero Form

Asymmetrical, heavily stylized, glowing visor, sharp points. Primary weapon: Blaster

BACKSTORY

Carter is an elementary school art teacher. He grew up watching *Power Rangers* and never lost his love for multi-colored costumed hero teams. This love inspired him to explore the history of *Super Sentai*, the Japanese show that inspired *Power Rangers*. He has collected a ton of action figures, morphers, and other toys. He hopes to share these with his children someday.

Carter's enthusiasm is infectious, especially when he is talking about his special interests. He speaks about things he loves with a passion that can melt even the iciest demeanor.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Change Script

Reaction ability; impose a penalty on the triggering action made by an enemy

Casting Call

Summons "extras" for a single attack against an enemy

RAINBOW BLUE

IDENTITY

Civilian Name

Liz

Pronouns

She/Her

Age

Early 40s

Orientation

Lesbian

APPEARANCE

Height

5'

Weight

100 lbs.

Human Form

Video game graphic tee, jeans, canvas sneakers, backpack

Superhero Form

Light armor with pixelated accents and visible circuitry. Primary weapon: Ranged (various)

BACKSTORY

Liz is a former gifted kid. She is a software engineer for a Silicon Valley tech startup. She works remotely and is very efficient, which gives her extra time to work on her own projects. She has ADHD and several unfinished projects that she lost interest in. She knows that she is meant to do something amazing but doesn't know what it is. She is very nerdy and loves both video games and comic books.

Liz is a lesbian and currently unpartnered. She often bemoans the dating landscape of her city and the dating apps she uses to find companionship, but she doesn't stop searching for her true love.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Observe

Learn a "Create Construct" skill from enemy that persists through fights; similar to *Final Fantasy*'s Blue Mage

Aim

Next turn, automatically perform Attack with significantly increased damage

RAINBOW PURPLE

IDENTITY

Civilian Name

Zephir

Pronouns

They/Them

Age

Late 30s

Orientation

Pansexual

APPEARANCE

Height

5'3"

Weight

220 lbs.

Human Form

Alternates between dress and casual sportswear

Superhero Form

Light armor with cloak and comedy/tragedy mask helmet. Primary weapon: Form changing dagger/pistol

BACKSTORY

Zephir is an actor. They work primarily as a company player in a local children's theatre but have also acted in more traditional plays. They believe that the most important truths can only be told through fiction.

They are pansexual and currently unpartnered. They were previously in a relationship with Rin, which ended due to differing needs. They remain friends with Rin, but the relationship has not gotten back to where it was previously. They feel like they are on the edges of the friend group following the dissolution of the relationship.

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Hide

Decreased likelihood of being targeted; changes to Surprise Attack while in effect

Surprise Attack

Inflict a status debuff on the enemy based on weapon mode. Dagger: Stun, Gun: Slow

Weapon Mode

Changes primary weapon mode between dagger and gun

SAMPLE LEVELS

The Hook: An Ordinary Night Out

As the game begins, a group of six friends are exploring a park inside a moderately sized city. Players can travel around the park and explore its various features, such as the pond, the dog park, and the playground. When they approach the playground, a loud crash is heard from the nearby woods, which begins the level's primary objective: investigating the disturbance.

Following the sound takes the player to a small walking path that eventually leads to a meteor crash site. There are small fires around, showing that it recently crashed and leading our players to believe (correctly) that this was the source of the noise. When the players get close to the meteor, it cracks open, and six slug-like creatures shoot out, one going to each character. The characters panic but are unable to react before the slugs disappear into their skin directly atop their spines. This event serves as the catalyst that provides players' powers and is an indirect introduction to the biocomputers that support the cast of protagonist characters.

Player Experience

The player's emotional journey through this level takes them from comfort to curiosity to wonder. The characters are comfortable as the game starts, spending time with their long-time friends doing a routine thing. Players are given the opportunity to explore and bring curiosity to the world around them, which is punctuated by the sound of crashing that causes them to investigate. Then there is a sense of wonder as the players experience an event that is not yet explained but



Plot Point: First Combat

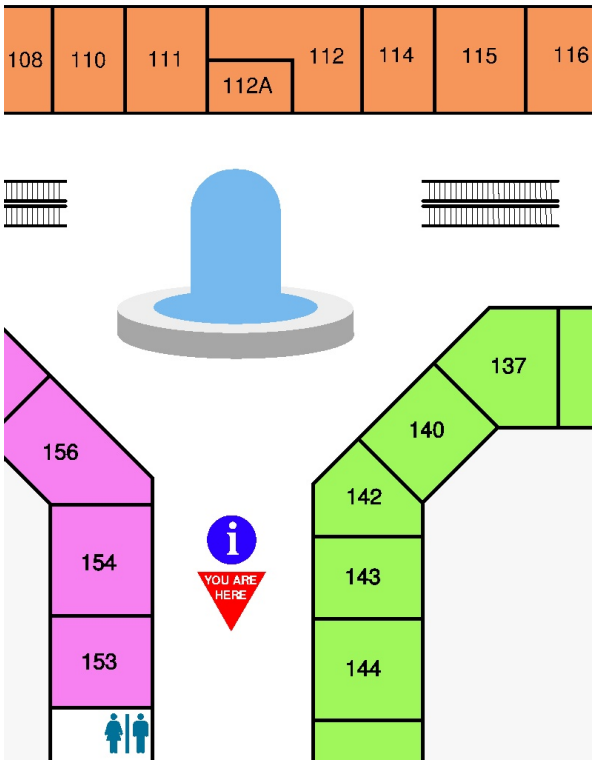
Between the opening level and the beginning of this level, players have discovered their powers and the biocomputers that are now permanently bonded to them but have not yet used their powers in any kind of combat scenario.

The level begins with the players arriving at a local shopping area where a monster is attacking civilians. This is their first experience with the monstrous forces of the game, which causes them to hesitate. In their time of indecision, the monster smashes the fountain and injures innocent people, which drives the team to act. They rush in to fight the monster, winning easily. This level also serves as a combat tutorial, so the player is guided through the fight to ensure a relatively easy victory.

After the fight, the team spends some time discussing the damage and devastation around them. Players can either leave immediately after this discussion or stay to help the injured and assist with cleanup. Staying will increase the public's perception of the team, which will have mechanical benefits later in the game. Whether they leave immediately or stay to assist, the team eventually separates to think about the situation they find themselves in.

Player Experience

Players begin this level with uncertainty, as they have not yet been given an opportunity to use their new powers. That uncertainty leads to urgency as the players are required to save civilians who are under threat and not prepared. The music will underscore this urgency. As the level teaches them how combat works, players will be empowered to complete the fight on their own with the knowledge they have been granted. Finally, the players are given the opportunity to feel responsibility by giving them the option to stay and help their community and being exposed to the Reputation system for the first time.



Pinch Point: Introduction to the Villain

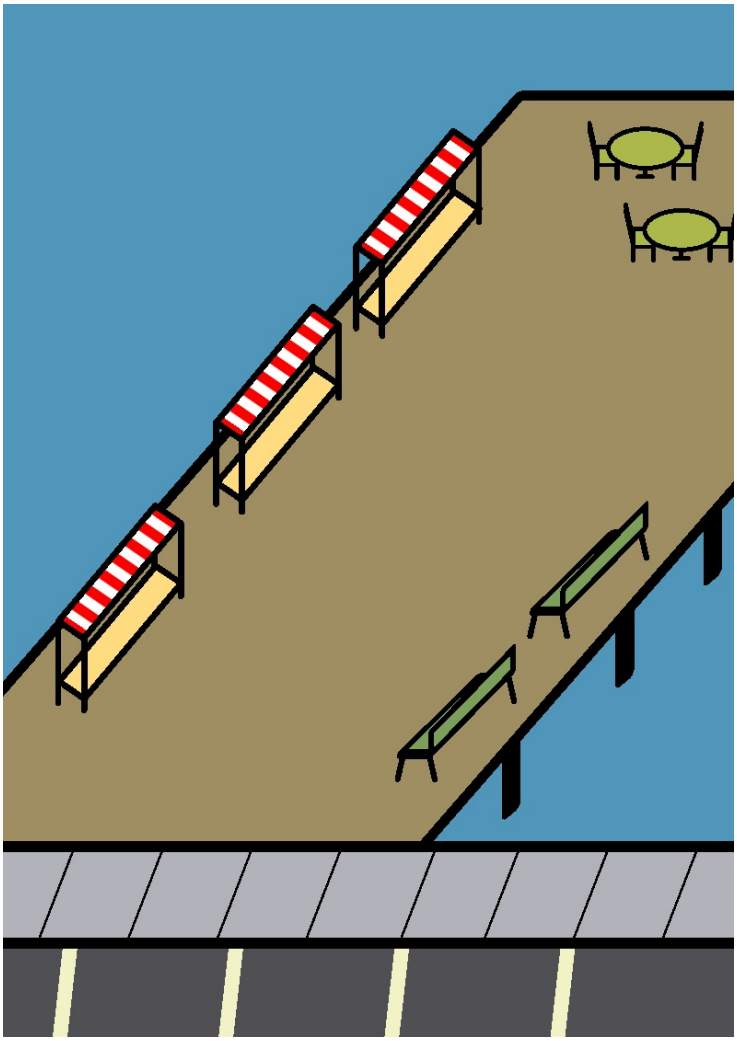
By this point, the team has been operating for a bit of time. Players have been able to explore and fight battles with monsters but do not know where they are coming from.

This level begins with the team arriving at the Pier, discovering what they believe to be just another average monster attack. They engage with the monster as normal, but just before the monster is defeated, it is joined by a large, menacing creature. This creature is more intentional than the monsters they have faced previously, and they have never had to face more than one monster at a time (excluding mooks). This changes the flow of battle completely and turns what was nearly a victory into a crushing defeat.

Following the battle, the newcomer introduces themselves as Vince O'Ruin. He mocks the team's strength, remarking that they "don't know why they were worried" and that they "won't debase themselves further by killing such weaklings." The team leaves, having suffered their first defeat and learning that there are much larger forces at play than they knew.

Player Experience

By this point in the game, players should feel confident about their abilities. They have yet to be truly tested either in combat or in the narrative. That confidence turns into shock when they experience the main villain, Vince O'Ruin, for the first time. After their crushing defeat, they will feel somewhat helpless but determined to improve.



Midpoint: Assault on Enemy Stronghold

After a series of battles with the monsters that are attacking the city, the team is tired of not making any progress on ending the threat for good. They know they can't just react but need to find a way to be proactive about the conflict. With this goal, they put their efforts toward locating the villain's base.

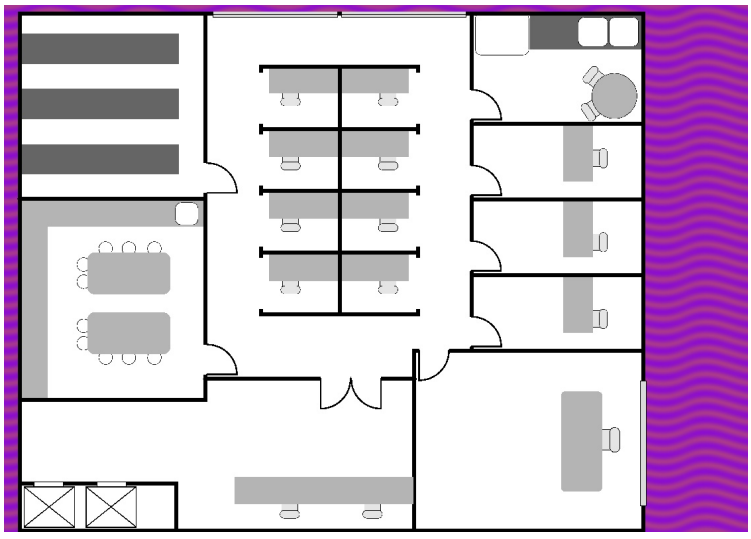
They catch a lucky break when a monster steps out of a portal in front of them. Alpha, the biocomputer bonded to Rin, scans the monster and determines that the monsters are coming from a pocket dimension, which explains how they just appear without anyone seeing them beforehand. The data they gather is enough to recreate the dimensional frequency, which allows them to access the villain's stronghold.

The team is shocked to discover that the villain's lair is not a ruined temple or an opulent castle, but is instead a standard, almost boring office building. They take the elevator to the floor where Vince O'Ruin's office is located, and search for any information on the villain's plans or how to stop him. They discover that the villain's goal is to connect Earth to his company's Head Office and strip it of resources. They also discover that he has done this to other planets, including the one the biocomputers came from.

When the players are ready to leave, they discover a veritable army of mooks waiting for them in the lobby. No matter how hard the player fights, more enemies always appear, so it is impossible for them to fight their way out of the scenario. The only way to end it is to go through the gauntlet and escape through the portal. When the players finally make it through the portal, it closes behind them. This is when they discover that Zephir did not make it through the portal and was left behind.

Player Experience

The determination from the players' introduction to the villain may be waning by now, so the player is provided with an opportunity to assault their headquarters, effectively reigniting that determination. Once again, players are faced with an opportunity to explore an area, though this time it is with a goal in mind, so the curiosity is tempered but remains as a feeling of discovery. When players are ambushed on the way out, there is pressure, both literally from the press of enemies around them and emotionally from the need to escape. Once the team is through the gauntlet, players will experience loss with the surprise (presumably unwilling) departure of Zephir.



Pinch Point: Betrayal

Following the loss of Zephir, the team gathers in their unofficial sanctum, Morgan's apartment/ studio. They are discussing how they will rescue Zephir when the front door opens and they walk in. The team is overjoyed and celebrates, but it is cut short when they get word of a monster attack at a tech company's offices downtown. The team gathers in the garage to head out, but Zephir attacks without warning. Zephir is significantly stronger than they had been and ends the fight quickly.

Zephir monologues before leaving, saying that they are happy they don't have to pretend to be friends with these weak, indecisive losers. They say that if they had waited on the team to rescue them, they would have died in that pocket dimension and they are glad they joined the winning team finally. They are particularly brutal to Rin, with whom they were previously in a romantic relationship. They also let slip that they couldn't risk the team interrupting their attack on the tech company, so Zephir was sent to take them out of commission.

After Zephir leaves, the team is disheartened and distraught. They have lost both a friend and a teammate, who is suddenly way more powerful than they are. Rin believes there is more to the story than just Zephir turning traitor but agrees that they need enough power to defend themselves and their community either way.

Player Experience

Players begin this level feeling a mix of confusion, shock, and grief at the loss of a main character. When Zephir returns, they will experience immediate relief, but that is snatched away as Zephir assaults them. Following their defeat, players will once again feel helpless and vulnerable, unsure of how to move forward. They have been attacked in their own home by someone they thought was a friend, and the uncertainty that causes both players and characters should feel equally impactful.

Plot Point: Visiting Synthax One

The biocomputers tell the team about a possible path to upgrading their powers, but that it will be dangerous. The biocomputers have been bonded to the team long enough to have completed the calculations for a portal back to their home planet, but that planet is plagued by war. They know that the Central Terminal should be able to increase their throughput, but for security purposes they were not programmed with the location of the terminal. They also won't have access to their powers while on the planet, since the biocomputers will need to recover enough energy to get them home. The team agrees, and the biocomputers work together to open a portal to their home planet.

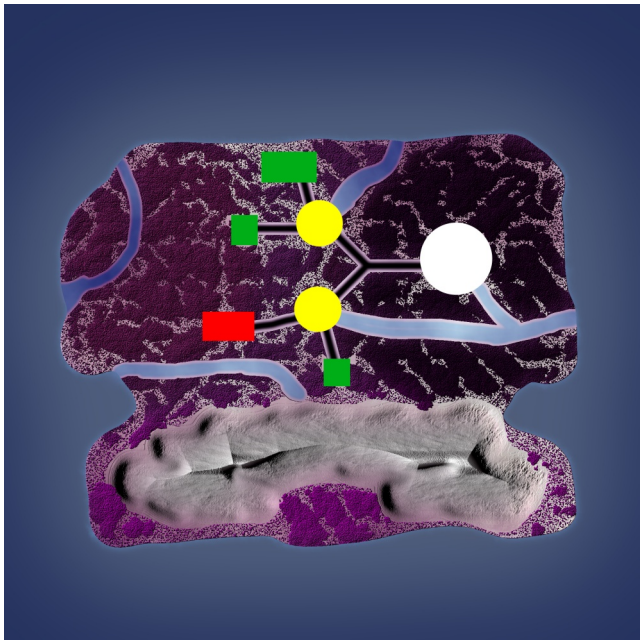
On Synthax One, players can explore the area and have a few points of interest to discover. There are burned out farms, the remains of a recently fought battle, and a village. There is little to see on the farms. If the player goes to the battlefield, they are asked to help evacuate wounded to the local village. They can also speak with soldiers to learn more about the war the planet has been fighting with the villain and why Vince O'Ruin is trying to steal resources from these planets.

In the village, players find clues to the location of the Central Terminal which leads them to a dangerous mountain. The team must fight several battles without access to their powers but eventually find the ruins that house the Central Terminal at the peak of the mountain. The biocomputers interface with the terminal and access increased processing power, which gives the team a new battle form and more powerful constructs.

The players return to the portal where they arrived and make a vow to each other and their biocomputer partners to return when Earth is safe.

Player Experience

On Synthax One, players are forced to play without their special abilities for the first time. This leaves them feeling vulnerable and anxious. As they explore, they will experience wonder and discovery as they see a fully alien world that is completely unlike Earth. Upon finding the information they need, players will be determined to get the new power despite their unpowered state. Once they have spoken to the Central Terminal, players will feel a sense of growth, not just from the power-up but from their new knowledge about the enemy.



Resolution: The Observatory Showdown

The team has powered up just in time for Vince O'Ruin's plans to enter their final stage. The team heads off to the observatory to put an end to the villainous plot to connect the worlds.

On the road to the observatory is a cliffside quarry area (a traditional tokusatsu battle arena). Waiting to block the path is Zephir along with an army of mooks. The team battles Zephir, using their new battle forms to win. Rin has an emotional moment with Zephir immediately following the battle, which throws off the last bit of mind control that O'Ruin had over Zephir. Zephir is apologetic and ashamed but pushes past it to rejoin the team for the final conflict.

The team enters the observatory and does battle with O'Ruin for the last time. It is a difficult battle, pushing each character to their limits. When the player finally defeats the boss, they shut down the process that would have connected the worlds. As they do so, they discover that a message was sent at the last moment, instructing Vince O'Ruin's assistant to start "Operation Atlantis" on Synthax One.

None of the team, including Zephir, know what Operation Atlantis is, but they know it must be trouble. The team prepares to return to Synthax One, knowing they won't be returning to Earth for a long time, if at all. This serves as an open ending for the game as well as a setup for a potential sequel or DLC.

Player Experience

As players begin the final level of the game, the determination they felt is still going strong. They have gotten more powerful and are feeling more confident in their abilities than ever. After defeating Zephir, they feel a moment of reconnection and wholeness that comes from reuniting as a team. Their battle with O'Ruin is hard-fought and will bring forward their mastery of their abilities and the game systems. The joy of victory follows, with the team celebrating their victory over the evil force. This lasts until the player discovers the message, which inspires a sense of anticipation and new purpose in them.